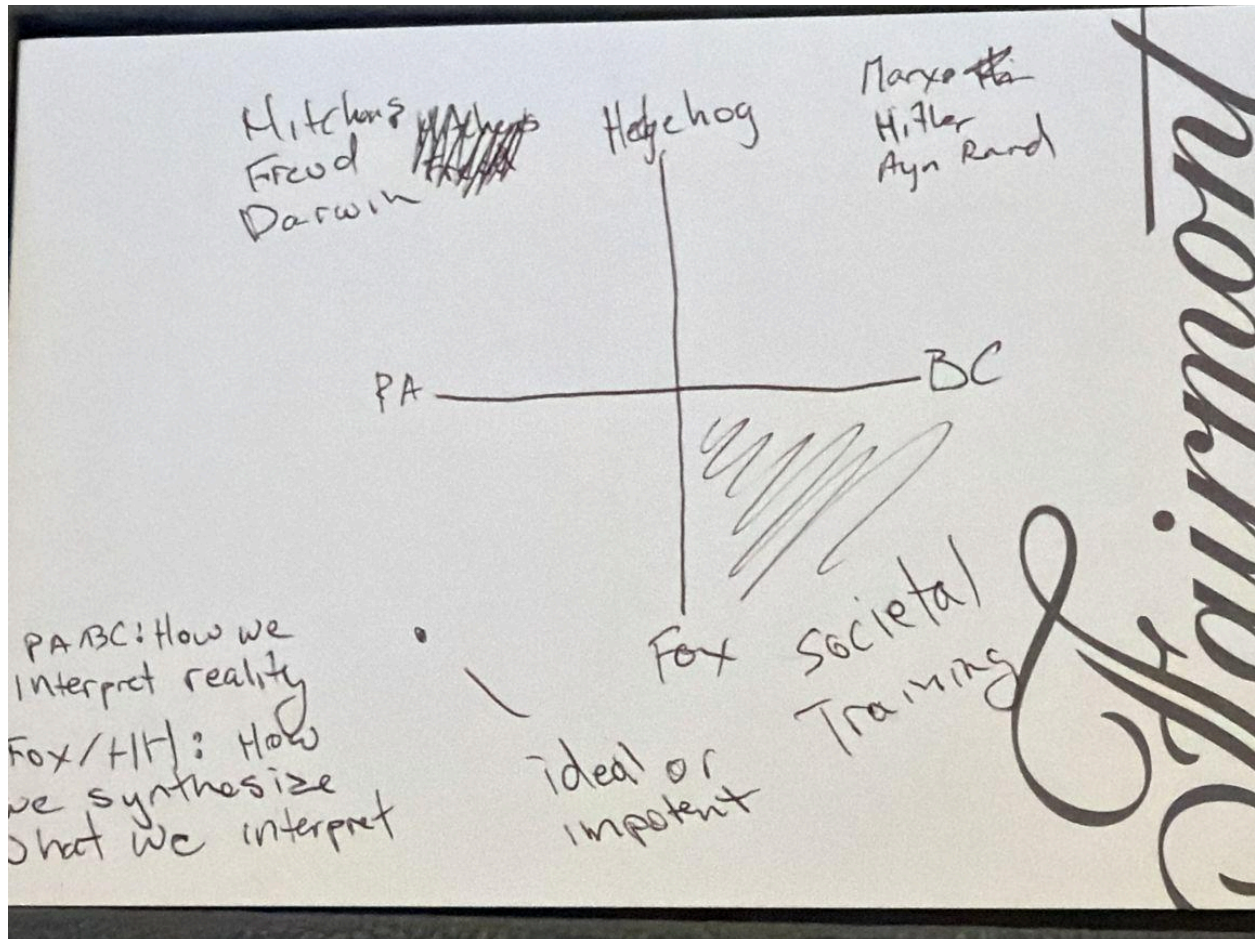


Chapter 6: Understanding Ourselves and Others: The Missing Dimension in Education



Little is more important in guiding and constructing the systems necessary for societal function than the understanding of the self: namely, our own, the spectrum of which behavioral patterns exist, and the population-level averages and tendencies of groups—both small and large. This is why I spent hundreds of thousands of words covering this topic throughout *StressHacked* and *The Stone Wall*. Literally nothing relating to our societal challenges, and the many grand solutions that have invariably failed, makes sense without first immersing oneself into this requisite knowledge. As such, the greatest failure of our education system is its refusal to acknowledge reality.

Namely, our educational paradigm ignores the fundamental contradictions of human nature, designing models based on how many of the ideologues curating it believe that people *should* think, rather than how they actually do. This failure stems from a persistent unwillingness to confront human nature as it actually exists, because for many, this confrontation is too painful, too real. It forces oneself to look into the mirror, wherein only the abyss stares back. Historically, this is precisely why two polar extremes have existed within our thinkers, whether they be novelists, psychological philosophers, political philosophers, artists, and many others. All of us exist within a spectrum of these two poles, although typically we will gravitate, usually strongly, towards one end of the spectrum.

On one side stands an army of the many, those who see a world they want, demanding reality conforms to their fantasy. On the other stand the few, those who seek to strip the illusions of reality bare, assessing it in its raw truth, unflinching and demanding nothing other than shared comprehension of reality,¹ so that we may design systems that fit within the frameworks we are given. This chasm between the two methods of thought creates a philosophical war between what we might call Blind Constructors² and Pragmatic Architects.³ This war has profound implications for how we understand ourselves and others, and consequently, for the success or failure of our educational systems.

The Human Nature Blind Spot

The debate over whether our emotions govern reason, or not, was one that ended up being quite heated when writing *StressHacked*, the discussion raging between myself and two of my editors, Vadim and Ljubomir. I believe the evidence points to this: we are slaves to our emotions,

¹ As I will explain in more detail towards the end of this chapter, our reality is inescapably filtered through our own emotions and perceptions. As such, the only objective reality is that there are as many subjective interpretations of it as there are human beings. Yet, this shall not prevent us from finding the shards of shared truth that we can collectively agree upon, utilizing honest, non-ideological discourse to confer intersubjective verification to our understanding of reality.

²

³ In *The Stone Wall*, I spoke about “architects” as being the designers of our misery and social imprisonment. Societal architects, in and of itself, is not a negative or destructive endeavor. Different philosophical, political, and economic architects devise plans and structures for an almost endless variety of purposes. Thinking like an architect is a reasonably common endeavor, in the grand scheme of things, and the entirety of this intellectual endeavor shouldn’t be vilified for the crimes of the few. The financial, economic, and bureaucratic architects working towards our subjugation are simply one strand of this general way of thought. This strand, or denomination, has evolved into something demonstrably harmful. For that reason and that reason alone, they are our enemies. We must separate that denomination, those within their ranks with the broad knowledge of what they are driving towards, from the majority who are working within the existing framework, or working on other frameworks within our larger societal construct.

our rational mind serving as a post hoc analytical justification for our decision-making process. I would argue that the evidence suggests this as the likely reality, as well.

Despite this, educational institutions systematically avoid what may be the most fundamental reality of human nature: emotion governs reasoning. Instead, we are taught the opposite, and explicitly so. This false assumption leads to education models that misfire—producing students unprepared for the real-world dynamics of power, status, and cognitive bias. By designing educational frameworks based on an idealized, rationalist view humanity cannot live up to, we create systems fundamentally misaligned with how humans actually think, feel, and behave. Our education system, leading the way in this epistemological collapse, sufficiently inculcates students to accept this foundational lie as truth, paving the way to a reality where said indoctrinated youth, when eventually graduating towards a professional career, utilize this false interpretation of reality in building their own systems based on their idealized view of humanity. Not only are these types of thinkers woefully ignorant, but they are also countless in number, and since each of their realities is different, the likelihood is that substantial portions of unthinking humans will be co-opted by the beliefs of these Blind Constructors, reliably regurgitating all of the mystically-driven slop, never failing to be further proselytized.

This single, but foundational, misunderstanding about human nature and cognition gives rise to everything wrong with our curricula and virtually every other system we have in place for governance and societal functioning. If humans were capable of acting solely on cognition, altering their emotional responses to different stimuli, without limitations, simply through altered educational strategies and societal structures, then humans could logically behave in any way you wish them to behave. This, however, is clearly a fantasy, as demonstrated by every attempt to socially engineer outcomes that clash with our innate nature. Even if the majority of us will still develop into Blind Constructors, we desperately need to attempt to train ourselves to think as Pragmatic Architects. In this way, even those of us prone to drifting towards ideology will have built-in checks to steer us towards a more pragmatic reality. To do this, we must educate our youth on critical truths about human dynamics, our wants, needs, and desires:

Power dynamics remain unacknowledged in the curriculum despite their pervasive influence in human affairs. Educational institutions portray themselves as meritocratic environments while operating through implicit hierarchies, teaching students to navigate power structures without explicitly acknowledging their existence. This creates graduates who understand power dynamics intuitively, all the while lacking the vocabulary and frameworks to address them

consciously—making them vulnerable to manipulation, and unable to create systems that appropriately account for power's influence.

To be sure, power dynamics *are* taught at universities and other institutions in the form of Marxism, which holds that “The history of all hitherto existing society is the history of class struggles” (Marx & Engels, 1848/2018). Marxism, including its liberal variants like Michel Foucault’s philosophy, seeks to retrofit all human relations into the framework of class struggle. Interestingly, Marxists at universities fail to systematically apply the Marxist critique to *their own institutions*, but, beyond this, it’s evident to me that other factors besides class [such as race] overdetermine material class realities. And beyond this, “determination” is, in Marxist language, “false consciousness” since we are capable of doing other than what we are induced to do by categories such as “class” or even “race.”

Status concerns similarly go unaddressed despite their profound impact on motivation and behavior. Humans are intensely status-conscious, yet education pretends that learning occurs in a status-neutral environment. The reality is that classroom participation, academic performance, and even subject selection are heavily influenced by status calculations. In short, kids will “follow the leader,” meaning their friend-group peers who have risen to the top of their organic hierarchy. By refusing to acknowledge this dimension of human psychology, education fails to effectively channel status concerns toward productive ends. Since they go unacknowledged, these ineradicable dynamics are left to fester, operating unconsciously—and often destructively.

Cognitive biases receive minimal attention despite fundamentally shaping how we process information. Research in cognitive psychology has identified dozens of systematic biases in human reasoning—from confirmation bias to availability heuristics to fundamental attribution error—yet these insights rarely inform educational practice. We continue teaching as if presenting information rationally will result in rational processing, ignoring how powerfully biases shape information interpretation. This creates graduates who remain unaware of their own cognitive limitations and are thus unable to compensate for them.

As I previously alluded, the educational system's refusal to acknowledge these fundamental aspects of human psychology stems from its alignment with what we might call the Blind Constructor viewpoint. As such, under the dangerous and misguided belief that humans can be molded into purely rational, universalist beings through proper instruction, we have developed systems that lead us astray, betray our nature, and mould our minds into thinking patterns that

amplify our worst ideological tendencies. Simultaneously, this framing leads to the common perception that Pragmatic Architects, those who see our nature and reality for what it is, are simply negative, pessimistic, even toxic.

Blind Constructors vs. Pragmatic Architects: The Philosophical Divide

This concept sat at the tip of my tongue for many years, perhaps the better part of two decades, unable to fully coalesce in my mind. Then, I began to notice a pattern between my love for certain forms of art, such as music and literature, and the visceral hate others have for it—taking keen notice of the behavioral patterns, and ideological rigidity, of those possessing said visceral hate. This is when I realized that the same phenomenon I was observing in politics and philosophy, which I have thus far spoken about in relation to educational constructions, was also present in the arts. This phenomenon I had observed was a fundamental division in how we understand human nature, which extends across virtually all domains in society. In their polarized and archetypical forms, two opposing camps emerge, representing fundamentally different orientations towards reality:

Blind Constructors attempt to impose theoretical frameworks onto reality, demanding that human nature conform to their intellectual constructs. They begin with abstract principles—whether equality, rational harmony, or utilitarian calculus—and expect humanity to reshape itself accordingly. This approach treats human nature as infinitely malleable, a blank slate to be written upon by education and social engineering. When humans inevitably fail to conform to these idealized models, Blind Constructors typically blame insufficient education, systemic problems, or moral failings rather than questioning their underlying assumptions about human malleability.

In short, when approaching the game of life, they envision the result they hope to occur, placing no mind on first understanding the rules of the game, and the unbreakable codes and guardrails that will keep them on track as they navigate it. Because they don't value the rules—in fact, they don't believe the rules exist—they never even attempt to learn them, blaming each failed attempt to progress on a glitch, system error, or some other anomaly outside of their control.

Historical examples abound: **Marxism**, as I already mentioned, imagines humans as naturally cooperative beings who, once freed from capitalist structures, will selflessly contribute according

to ability and take only according to need—ignoring our innate tendencies towards self-interest, status-seeking, and competitive behavior. **Utilitarianism** attempts to reduce human motivation to a simple calculus of pleasure and pain, disregarding the complex, contradictory nature of human desires and values. **Spinoza** constructed an ethical system that prioritizes reason over the passions, defined as *passive affects*, often writing as though the highest form of human life would be one in which these passive affects are transformed and their hold diminished. In doing so, he underestimated the degree to which what he himself called the “passions” are not peripheral to human reasoning, but central to it, perhaps even a primary driver of cognition, thought, and action. While Spinoza acknowledged that human beings are in fact governed by their passions, he treated freedom as a limiting ideal in which adequate understanding progressively transforms confused affect, rather than fully confronting the reality that emotion precedes, structures, and constrains reason itself.

As I wrote in *The Stone Wall*, this is why Marxism can never be disproven in the eyes of Marxists—each attempt is just evidence of humans being flawed, perhaps perverted by corrupt systems, and as such not a “true attempt” at Marxism. This phenomenon has also been observed many times when religious prophets fail to deliver their predictions. With each failure, their flock grows larger, believing more deeply.

Pragmatic Architects, by contrast, begin by observing human behavior as it actually exists. They watch, contemplate, and track behavioral patterns to their root. Through this careful assessment, they are eventually able to recognize the immutable aspects of human nature. Through this enlightened understanding, our capacity for both cooperation and competition, our emotional processing, our status concerns, and our tribal instincts all become apparent, trackable, with responses to various situations growing increasingly more predictable over time.

At the core of this approach, Pragmatic Architects first learn the rules, and only after fully mastering the unbreakable codes of the game do they seek to build frameworks. Since they understand the rules of the game cannot be altered, bent, or broken, the frameworks they develop are designed to work within these constraints. This approach acknowledges human limitations while still seeking to create systems that channel human tendencies towards productive ends, simultaneously seeking to mitigate the most destructive aspects of our nature.

Thinkers in this tradition include **Nietzsche**, who recognized the role of power dynamics and status concerns in human psychology long before modern research confirmed these insights.

Dostoevsky understood the contradictory, irrational aspects of human behavior, portraying characters driven by unconscious motivations that they themselves barely comprehend. **Orwell** saw how tribal affiliations and power dynamics shape political behavior, often overriding rational self-interest. These thinkers didn't celebrate human flaws; in fact, they presented them as tragedies. Despite the presence of tragedy in our existence, they insisted that any viable philosophy must accommodate said tragedies, as the unfortunate realities of our existence will remain whether we acknowledge them or not.

As I previously mentioned, many instinctively resort to the accusation that Pragmatic Architects are simply negative pessimists who lack both vision and moral aspirations.⁴ This obtuse position demonstrates how little the critics comprehend about our reality, as the reality is that the Pragmatic Architects understand that effective systems must be built upon accurate models of human behavior. To put it bluntly, a bridge designed without accounting for gravity will collapse regardless of the engineer's noble intentions⁵; similarly, social systems designed without accounting for human nature inevitably fail, often catastrophically.⁶

⁴ The ideas expressed here broadly resemble the larger philosophical debate opposing ideal and non-ideal theory, respectively embodied by John Rawls and Amartya Sen. To put it simply, ideal theory describes society as it ought to be, and makes prescriptions to get there (which is, of course, practically impossible, as the cure doesn't match the illness). Non-ideal theory, instead, strives to describe reality as it is, and then suggests improvements without ever aiming for a "perfect" end-state.

However, the parallels with my proposed distinction between Blind Constructors and Pragmatic Architects end here, for two reasons. First, the ideal vs. non-ideal debate is concerned with society as a whole, whereas the focus here is on human nature and its peculiar expression in each individual. Second, while ideal and non-ideal theories attempt to disprove each other, the objective here is to reconcile the two opposing epistemologies, acknowledging that society can, does, and should include both Blind Constructors and Pragmatic Architects, instead of favoring only one or the other.

⁵ One can argue that this is an unrealistic example because an engineer has no ideological reason to disbelieve in gravity, despite the pleas of Flat Earthers, David Wolfe, and others like this—at least not yet. However, historical examples like Lysenkoism, which is a form of biology predicated on communist axioms, show that ideology does creep into hard sciences on occasion. Germ theory is currently under attack by certain thinkers; one can imagine the existence of doctors and surgeons who increasingly disbelieve in germ theory.

⁶ Philosophers like to say that "ought implies can," meaning that an obligation only makes sense if the person can actually do what is being demanded. They also insist on the is-ought distinction, meaning that a fact about how people are does not say how people should be. Yet, while true, these two points do not tell us to ignore reality. They tell us to treat it as a constraint. Just because people, in general, have innate tendencies leading to fear or aggressive reactions to those from outside of their race, culture, or even socioeconomic class, does not mean we should normalize or justify unbridled actions along these lines. It does, however, mean we must acknowledge these tendencies, and work within what is true about ourselves to construct societal norms which mitigate the worst of our behavior, without outright denying what is innate within our behavior. If we do not, the societal demands will ultimately fail due to impossibility of adherence, and when they fail they will, almost certainly, lead to a pendulum swing which amplifies and exacerbates the very traits the demands were meant to subdue. That is the difference between the Pragmatic Architect and the Blind Constructor: one builds norms for real people, and the other writes norms as if people were different.

To date, no societal system has ever been designed by Pragmatic Architects, nor has a civilization that strives to think like Pragmatic Architects been produced. Why is this? I believe the answer is probably too cynical for most, but to put it bluntly, it is because the majority prefer comforting lies over hard truths. When voices of reason scream from the rooftops, the townspeople instead flock to the shyster deceiving them, or the dogmatic evangelist promising a fairy tale. In this manner, in some ways, the Pragmatic Architects are failing, categorically, *to be pragmatic*. To truly lead their concepts to victory, perhaps they—or I—by necessity need to dress them in the clothing of everything my archetypical brethren in thought despise. Maybe I shouldn't put this in print, but it's 11:34 PM, and in the words of Kyle Morton from the band Typhoon:

*I'm hoping for
A song that will come to me when I'm asleep
Because I can't lie

And so I can't write. (x)*

This Division Revealed Through Literature

I spoke about the visceral, palpable hate and disgust many Russians have shown to me when speaking about Fyodor Dostoevsky in *The Stone Wall*. I spent what for many would be an inordinate, even obsessive, amount of time thinking about the “why” in this. Eventually, when I began conceptualizing my polarized archetypes this Chapter is framed around, I sought the “antithesis” to Dostoevsky, pausing to consider *my* reactions to that writer's works. James Joyce came to mind, amongst others. Indeed, Joyce, after continued reflection, felt the most fitting. When his work comes up, particularly his so-called masterpiece *Ulysses*, I remain physically incapable of expressing my disdain for whoever is praising it. I cannot for the life of me understand who enjoys reading that vacuous crap, devoid of any soul, any truth, *any humanity*, a monstrosity of technical control and perfection of prose that leaves me somewhat impressed, but wondering, “what's the point?”

For those who haven't had the displeasure (or pleasure, depending on your epistemological orientation), James Joyce builds intricate literary puzzles, prioritizing structure and reconfiguring emotion to the point that it seems dismissed entirely. In stark contrast, Dostoevsky tears through structure, exposing raw human contradiction. In short, Joyce refines; Dostoevsky confronts.

Joyce's works, particularly *Ulysses* and *Finnegans Wake*, are highly structured, filled with linguistic complexity, intertextual references, and an almost mathematical precision in form. He treats literature as an intellectual exercise, where meaning is embedded in the architecture of language. For me, literature, and art in general, require something more. To move me, to make me truly care, art requires the raw immediacy of human experience. To prevent myself from being too hyperbolic, of course, some emotion exists in his work, but it is aestheticized, filtered through layers of detachment and technical manipulation.

Dostoevsky, in my opinion, embodies the Pragmatic Architect approach. His novels are filled with tormented, self-destructive characters who wrestle with guilt, power, and existential dread. Dostoevsky rejects technical perfection as an illusion. His works, such as *The Brothers Karamazov* and *Crime and Punishment*, are messy, contradictory, and emotionally raw, mirroring the chaotic, unpredictable nature of real human existence. His writing is driven by moral agony, self-destruction, and existential crisis. As I wrote about in *StressHacked*, and then again in *The Stone Wall*, Dostoevsky never fails to bring me to tears.

While Joyce constructs a meticulous, artificial world of linguistic innovation, Dostoevsky captures the unfiltered, brutal reality of human existence by allowing his characters to unravel, their thoughts spilling onto the page with unmediated intensity. To paraphrase my own writing, Dostoevsky's work is like watching a train crash in slow motion. You know what will happen, because you see yourself, and those close to you, in his characters. His narratives unfold organically towards the eventual collapse, and you read them as if they were unraveling in real-time. Dostoevsky forces his readers to confront the darkest depths of human nature, dragging them into the abyss headfirst.

Dostoevsky's *Notes from Underground* serves as perhaps the most profound example of this contrast between Blind Constructors and Pragmatic Architects. The wall that the underground man confronts—the wall of determinism, of mathematical certainty, of natural law—represents the immutable constraints of reality that Blind Constructors pretend don't exist or believe they can overcome through sheer ideological force. The underground man, despite his torment, is unable to ignore this wall. However, despite its reality, he refuses to comply, smashing himself to bits against it. He acknowledges these constraints while simultaneously asserting the human right to desire, to act irrationally, to express self-will even when it leads to self-destruction.

I wrote in *The Stone Wall* that there is another option: we must stare at the wall calmly, focus on the pain that we feel from its existence, first. We must work through this devastation, come to terms with it, and then carefully move forward in a mission to study the wall, learn about it, and eventually figure out how to erect shelving, ladders, maybe even tunnels underneath, if possible. We can use it to support structure, accepting it as an immutable fixture of our existence, a reality with the capacity to help us. Because the wall does help us, it gives us clarity, information, and leads us to the truth. Through these gifts, and despite the pain, the stone wall is in many ways our greatest ally. We cannot exist without it.

Of course, *Notes from the Underground*, being a short novella, is not the best example to contrast with *Ulysses*. A better comparative example of the contrast of which I write is found when dissecting Joyce's *Ulysses* next to Dostoevsky's *The Brothers Karamazov*. *Ulysses* is a towering feat of technical ambition, a novel obsessed with form and linguistic play that requires active decryption, coming in at a staggering 265,000 words. It bores, however, with the length no more impressive than if it were a fraction, since it is little more than a technical display. Whereas *The Brothers Karamazov* presents a brutal, immediate confrontation with the contradictions of faith, doubt, and human suffering. Despite being substantially longer than *Ulysses*, Dostoevsky's masterpiece never bores, nor does it lose the interest of any reader possessing the strength to attempt it. Those who give up on it give up for other reasons, such as internal torment or lack of comprehension.

Leo Tolstoy, by necessity, must make an appearance in this section. Readers may recall my assertion, made in Chapter 16 of *The Stone Wall*, that Aleksandr Dugin finds philosophical kinship with Tolstoy, not Dostoevsky, with a footnote explaining my rationale. That footnote was an explicit foreshadowing of this very chapter in *Manufacturing Minds*. However, Tolstoy, of whom I am not a fan, offers yet another literary perspective—one that represents philosophical Blind Construction rather than the technical Blind Construction I explained regarding the works of James Joyce.

Tolstoy's approach to literature is deeply philosophical and moral. He built his novels with the express intent of using literature to define, refine, and spread a universal moral truth. His works, particularly *War and Peace* and *Anna Karenina*, reflect a grand, structured view of human nature, where morality can be understood, history follows discernible patterns, and suffering ultimately serves a higher purpose. His later work, *Resurrection*, becomes even more didactic, enforcing his absolute belief in moral progress and human redemption. Readers may recall I

mentioned that it was Tolstoy, after all, who funded the escape of the Doukhobors (soul wrestlers), an egalitarian anti-hierarchical community within the Orthodox Christian faith, helping them with finances and safe passage to leave Russia, where they faced imminent oppression or execution, to resettle in Alberta and British Columbia, Canada.

Tolstoy, in this manner, offers comfort to many. Comfort through a fantasy, a vision of reality in which goodness prevails, and our nature changes. The triumph of good over evil, with all its holy glory. Dostoevsky, however, rejects the notion that human nature can be neatly understood or refined into a moral framework. He does not offer redemption as a certainty, nor does he believe in a universal moral truth. His novels plunge into contradiction, suffering, and irrationality—showcasing that human nature is not governed by reason or grand historical movements. Instead, we experience our turgid existence through the lens of personal agony, directed by subconscious drives and raw emotion. Dostoevsky, in short, offers the antithesis of comfort.

One reality that exists in many works of art, literature, and modern-day film and television, is that of the redemption story. Characters will be built as immoral, broken, and incapable of doing better. Then, tragedy strikes. The community, or loved ones, are at risk. This previously vilified character, who we believed to be beyond redemption, without fail acts exactly when necessary, sacrificing themselves for the greater good and dying a hero. This narrative is powerful for people, because it whispers a lie into our ears: you don't need to do better today, in the end you will be given a single big moment to act, to redeem yourself, and this grand gesture can and will erase all of your crimes, wipe away your guilt, and restore the clarity in the rosefied vision of yourself you fight to maintain.

Tolstoy offers this redemption, this delusion, although not as hyperbolic as modern cinema. Tolstoy sees moral progress as possible—his characters, even when flawed, can find clarity and redemption through moral conviction. Dostoevsky views morality as a battlefield where faith and doubt, good and evil, self-destruction and transcendence coexist simultaneously, often without resolution. A clear contrast emerges when comparing Tolstoy's *War and Peace*, which presents human history as structured and comprehensible, unfolding according to more profound moral and philosophical laws, with Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment*, where history and morality are portrayed as violent, irrational, and irreconcilable forces. Where Tolstoy sees order and meaning, Dostoevsky sees chaos and suffering. Perhaps this reality regarding *Crime and*

Punishment is why I couldn't stop the tears from flowing as I read it, sobbing like a baby, an experience two of the editors working with me shared was similar to their own.

Musical Expression of Human Nature

If I had to guess how many times I have listened to Sergei Rachmaninoff's Piano Concerto No. 3, I'd conservatively say it numbers in the hundreds, but wouldn't for a second be surprised if it was in the thousands. I've given every single performance of the piece a try, enjoying most, despising a few. The piece has moved me to tears before, and while it does not always reliably do this, it does always make me feel something. Many in my life assume that because I love Rachmaninoff to such an extreme, I must love other famous "classical composers," by which they typically mean pianists from the Baroque and Romantic periods. So, it comes as a shock to them when I am not only dismissive, but openly vocal in my disdain for the composer, whom I am most commonly asked if I like: Mozart. In short, within my framework, I assert that Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart was the musical kindred spirit to James Joyce, whereas Rachmaninoff shared his telos with Fyodor Dostoevsky.

When first explaining my outright dislike for Mozart's music, from an emotional standpoint, I am more often than not met with incredulity. Of note, this reaction tends to come from individuals who have *never heard of Rachmaninoff*, despite Rachmaninoff's Piano Concerto No. 2 routinely, I believe more than any other piece, being voted the greatest composition ever written by the listeners at Classical.fm—more on this later—and my favorite piece, Piano Concerto No. 3, widely heralded as "the Everest of piano concertos," and similar attributions, by experts within the art. In short, similar to Joyce but to an even greater extent, I have enormous respect for the technical talent Mozart possessed, yet talent alone is insufficient to move me when it comes to the arts. Mozart's music is built for symmetry, achieving technical perfection but holding emotion at a distance. Like Joyce, this is not to say that Mozart's music was without emotion. More, the emotion he wrote into his pieces was restrained, expected, and wholly contrived to fit the formulaic design he intended.

Rachmaninoff, by contrast, plunges the listener into the fiery chaos of an emotional war, particularly in his Piano Concerto No. 3, which is relentless, overwhelming, and ultimately refuses resolution. Rachmaninoff demanded everything from his listeners, and any who dared to perform this piece. For myself, the passage between roughly 6:50 and 13:20 serves as the pinnacle of authentic human expression confined only to instrumental notes, with a particular

focus on the short explosion of chaos between roughly 11:50 and 13:20. In this eruption, one may imagine that the pianist is impulsively deciding which keys to strike in each moment. The lingering hold on certain keys, the hesitation before others, and then the awkward, prolonged pauses contrasted with rushed stumbles forward create an extraordinary effect. Of course, the pianist is not deciding which notes to strike at each moment, but the manner in which the piece is composed creates this illusion with startling precision, leading to a profoundly human experience—one that simultaneously requires technical mastery, yet paradoxically disregards it to create the intended effect.

Only a handful of pianists can master this piece in both technique and expression, and even then, it remains physically and emotionally draining. Where Mozart's compositions represent controlled theoretical perfection, and Rachmaninoff's No. 2 offers a more accessible emotional journey, Piano Concerto No. 3 is suffering incarnate—a brutal, unpolished expression of raw emotion that refuses to be tamed by technique.

The most accomplished performers and deep musical thinkers recognize Piano Concerto No. 3 as the pinnacle of artistic and intellectual achievement precisely because it embodies this uncompromising authenticity and emotional truth. Vladimir Horowitz, widely celebrated as one of the greatest interpreters of Rachmaninoff's work, described it as "the most difficult piece ever written for piano and orchestra. It is music that demands everything from the performer—not just technique but an understanding of its depths." Even Rachmaninoff himself struggled with its execution, famously remarking that it was "written for elephants," an indication of the staggering stamina, reach, and power required.

Even then, when first released, Rachmaninoff's Piano Concerto No. 3, while as a whole receiving mixed reviews, in personal performance as the soloist was universally panned. Critics believed he was making mistakes, that his playing was bad, not realizing the intentionality and the intended effect it created. I suspect others felt a deep pain, or anger, and were not conscious of why they felt this way. So, they simply rationalized that the technical performance was sloppy. It took a full decade for critics and listeners to comprehend what Rachmaninoff had done, intentionally, and appreciate the talent and genius behind it.

I stated that it feels as if no performer could possibly recreate the exact performance twice, and for the timestamps I implored the reader to consider, I stand by this feeling as an accurate representation of truth. No soloist I have listened to has recreated the same performance twice.

The emotion may remain consistent, the mastery of the pauses, the stumbles, but the effects occur on different notes, with varying intensities. This is, perhaps, why different interpretations of the music lead me to different emotional states. What emotion is the soloist expressing? One of sorrow, or that of an individual engulfed in an acute emotion, whether it be anger, panic, or a feeling otherwise causing acute distress.

For this reason, Piano Concerto No. 3 is for the few, but Rachmaninoff's Piano Concerto No. 2 is for the many. Why, exactly, is this the case? A composer's self-described masterpiece, the one heralded by his critics and the soloists endeavoring to perform it as the pinnacle, is objectively unpopular with the general audience; yet the piece that some argue is the closest to it in style, the piano concerto that directly preceded it, is debatably the most popular and universally acclaimed composition ever written. The answer lies in intensity.

Rachmaninoff's Piano Concerto No. 2 serves as a bridge between the extremes of which I write, offering powerful emotion while maintaining technical structure and accessibility. It is a gateway between the music of Mozart and the pure emotional chaos and relentless onslaught of Rachmaninoff's Piano Concerto No. 3. In short, Piano Concerto No. 2 leads the listener to experience a sorrow that drags them further into the abyss than many other composers, while maintaining control and technical virtuosity, before eventually lifting them back to resolution. The resolution allows them to feel exhilarated from the sorrow, to forget they were immersed in it, ending with a feeling of being simply moved. In Piano Concerto No. 3, Rachmaninoff makes no attempt to lift the listener out of the abyss, trampling them before dragging them down, leaving them stranded to crawl their way out on their own. This is a different kind of beast, a more jarring experience that is not, so to speak, for everyone.

Vadim suggested I read an article by Slavoj Žižek (2017)⁷ regarding his classical musical preferences. Vadim knows I despise the man as a thinker, and wanted to see what I'd take away from his likes—and his strong dislikes, including his dismissal of Rachmaninoff as being lowly and “kitsch.”

I admit, I entered into the reading with a completely different view of Žižek. My opinion of him was an incorrect caricature, and I had previously unfairly labeled him in a manner I do not believe rightfully classifies him. Previously, I thought Žižek was a typical Marxist-adjacent Blind Constructor, contemplating whether his positions contradictory to Marxism were incoherent, or intentional lies and propaganda.

Reading the short piece that Vadim sent, followed by some substantial deep thought, led me to a different conclusion. In fact, Vadim—who appreciates Žižek as a thinker, even if not all of his politics—has stated that he now generally agrees with my assessment. To me, not being a Žižek expert, this is telling for the power of the hypothesis that I am outlining throughout this chapter. It should not come as too absurd for those paying attention, as if Facebook can understand us better from 100 likes, in regards to predicting our political preferences, than our spouse—an extreme claim backed by research—what can properly trained human minds achieve when these innate realities within us are finally explored?

Žižek, a man I consider to be one of the most dishonest and, as such, dangerous intellectuals alive, is a Neo-Marxist who relies upon sarcastic irony,⁸ misdirection, and half-truths manipulated in strategic ways to fit his worldview. That said, he represents an interesting anomaly within this spectrum of Blind Constructors and Pragmatic Architects. In reading about

⁷ Vadim adds, “Alex responds to Žižek in a somewhat testy fashion. I feel compelled to preface this. The problems with Žižek are captured well by Alex. However, I will state a few words in Žižek's defense. Žižek's principle idea, which originates with Jacques Lacan (since there is no original thought possible; and it has predecessors even before Lacan), is that there is a ‘symbolic order’ to our interactions with humans as humans. Consider signs in the Peircean sense, which I outlined in a previous chapter: signs spur you to do something, and whatever you do, says Žižek, has ideological meaning. When you put on the stone-washed jeans, you are acting out an ideology.

Žižek's insight is that the symbolic order itself, what Lacan calls the Big Other, is what we fear as our political oppressor, and not any individual or even social system. It is the ‘invisible’ system of sign-regulation that is our foe, and this is why Louis Althusser, who Žižek quotes, recognizes that we stop on the street when someone shouts “hey asshole!” at us. The amount of oppression, undergirded by trauma, which we experience is what ensures we are counter-revolutionary, afraid of not only other people but invisible systems.

Speaking of revolution, Žižek admits we *need* the Big Other, and this is why he emphasizes “ways of life” as crucial for Europe in its attempts to integrate outsiders. This is why he is skeptical of the revolutionary project in South Africa. And this is why, communist label-aside, the man really is a conservative, if you look past the jokes. Someone who is conservative within a left-wing tendency is still closer to my ethical view of the world than a left-wing radical.”

his musical tastes, both his favorites (namely Wagner, but also Schoenberg, Schumann, and others) and the telling dismissal and indictment of the “lowly and kitsch” Rachmaninoff, it is clear to me that Žižek is a Pragmatic Architect who chooses to exist within an intentional Blind Constructor framework. Žižek sees the wall, he is aware of it, perhaps all too aware, staring at it obsessively, anxiously, perhaps unable to look away—but, unable to exist next to it at the same time, to live within the reality where he sees the wall, appreciates it, even grows to be moved by it.

Žižek rejects performative emotion, preferring cold, sterilized music, devoid of the need for any resolution, as there was no controlled struggle in the first place. Žižek sees the lie in these highly structured and predictable formulaic arcs, which most Blind Constructors gravitate to, and when one can see the lie, the lie ceases to hold power over the beholder. The band Manchester Orchestra has fitting lyrics in their song “Top Notch,” which perfectly elucidate this:

*It didn't really matter how it happened in the end
Cause when it happened, you react to it with this apathetic wince
So you try to wash it out but that's a stain that won't dissolve
And we all believed in ghosts until you walked into the wall*

So give up. So give up. So give up. (Manchester Orchestra, 2014)

For Žižek, the wall represents too much pain; it is too unbearable for him, precisely the reason that he cannot listen to the likes of Rachmaninoff. Instead of *destroying himself by smashing himself into the wall in isolation, hoping it will eventually break*—the typical actions of many Pragmatic Architects—best psychologized in Dostoevsky’s Underground Man—Žižek chose a different path, a path that a select few choose. A path that has led to unfathomable societal harm. I wrote about this path in Chapter 20 of *The Stone Wall*: the Marxist generals, so pained by their sexual rejection that they “find religious faith” in their emotional revelation regarding the philosophical coherence and similarity between class struggle and sexual struggle. This is not Žižek, but it is close.

Žižek is pained by something, something deep. Something he is repressing and cannot face. Yet, he is not a *true believer*, as he has *never stopped seeing the wall for what it is*. This is why he relies more on comedy, less on condescension. This is why he aims to make a fool of his opponents, such as the dominant exchanges in his debate with Jordan Peterson, who was woefully unprepared to debate Žižek, not understanding who and what Žižek represents.

This is the danger of Žižek. He is atypical, a Pragmatic Architect so pained by some past tragedy that he willfully turns to lies, lies that he most certainly knows are just that, weaponizing them in the service of an ideology he certainly realizes is likewise built upon lies. How do you debate a man like this? What angle will he take, what ethical standards, or intellectual integrity will he hold himself to? The tragedy with Žižek is that not all of his positions are incoherent. He is not a traditional Marxist, and as such, has incorporated legitimate and logical concessions.

This matters little, as without understanding the source of his pain, one cannot get to the root of his motivating drivers. Without understanding the triggers that compel him to lie, manipulate, and seek domination over others, it becomes an arduous, almost impossible, task to untangle his often paradoxical belief systems, some built upon truthful concessions, others premeditated lies, to fully assess and appreciate his work or isolate any potential contributions. In some ways, Žižek represents a more serious risk than another known liar I have written about, Aleksandr Dugin, due solely to the more elegant obfuscations of his intentions, elaborate techniques, and mystery of his desires. Of course, in *actuality*, when assessing each man, this is not true, only being true in *possibility*.

Žižek would not have usually commanded such a divergence from my point, except that what I learned about him, at least what I believe that I learned, is precisely the point of the chapter. In reading a few short pages where Žižek explains his musical likes and dislikes, I feel I now understand the man better than the culmination of all of his actual statements and positions of which I am aware. Previously, there was incoherence, so I was forced to fit the man into an archetype that he did not belong to. Now, through understanding the man to a greater degree, his positions, while still contradictory and seemingly incoherent, become more coherent in accepting Žižek's flaws, his humanity.

Perhaps it is too late for him; he is nearing the end, being 76 at the time of this writing, but through understanding the general psychology that led to the man we know as Slavoj Žižek, perhaps we can free future epistemological and intellectual peers burdened with similar pain to similar tragic fates. For fans of Žižek, Vadim included, think of what the man could have done if unshackled from the unresolved pain that led him to invert his own epistemic tendency? In the future, hopefully, we will have men and women of this caliber able to contribute, to build within our reality, rather than lie to protect themselves from confronting it.

The Pattern in Modern Music

Perhaps more easily accessible are the modern comparators that speak to the opposite poles on this reality-constructing, and deconstructing, spectrum. On the Blind Constructor side, groups like Coldplay and The Eagles exemplify technical perfection, in the sense that their songs follow a precise, formulaic emotional arc. This strategy serves to create polished, clean, and emotionally accessible music designed for mass appeal. Their melodies are simple, euphoric, and uplifting—often following familiar chord progressions that evoke an immediate but somewhat surface-level emotional response. Their production is immaculately structured, deliberately avoiding dissonance, unpredictability, or any elements that might disrupt accessibility.

Coldplay, for example, crafts anthems of love, hope, and longing. Songs like "Fix You" and "Viva La Vida" build steadily towards soaring catharsis, where the polished emotional arcs ensure that even sadness is rendered comforting. Similarly, The Eagles construct their songs with grand harmonies and a nostalgic, romanticized vision of life. Every note is intentional, every harmony pristine; their music adheres to tight, traditional structures. Their music is meant to be consumed easily, following tight song structures and rarely deviating from traditional verse-chorus arrangements. Themes of the American dream and nostalgic longing permeate their work, even in tracks like "Hotel California," where excess is presented in a smooth, palatable manner.

Muse represents yet another fascinating dimension of this spectrum. They create music that is hyper-polished and theatrical, often engineered to create spectacle and impact. Their approach is rigid, all-encompassing, and deeply structured. They build entire sonic worlds around their ideas. They do not question their grand narratives—whether about dystopian political corruption ("Uprising"), authoritarian control ("The Resistance"), or any of their other thematic political and ideological symphonies, approaching their conclusions with certainty.

Muse reinforces their worldview through maximalist technical precision, constructing towering, larger-than-life compositions where every note, production choice, and theatrical moment serves their central vision. Unlike the organic, exploratory compositions of bands I'll discuss next, every Muse song follows a precise, structured arc designed to maximize dramatic impact. As an aside, despite the lack of existential questioning, or raw humanity, I do appreciate Muse—and to a lesser extent, Coldplay, and The Eagles. For me, some of these modern forms of music, even when epistemologically opposed to my prevailing intellectual framework, are

capable of striking certain chords within my *self*, resonating with me in appreciable, albeit less visceral ways than my favorites. More on this later.

Their approach places Muse firmly in the Blind Constructor camp, but with a crucial difference from bands like Coldplay. Where Coldplay creates music designed to comfort and soothe, Muse creates music designed to overwhelm and convince. In short, Muse, as opposed to Coldplay and The Eagles, take opposite pathways to the same destination: a predetermined and contrived destination. Muse are the revolutionaries who stare at the wall and deny it is an impediment, whereas Coldplay and The Eagles represent those amongst us who deny there is a wall, choosing to focus on select positive aspects of our existence, so that they are never forced to confront the harsh realities bubbling under the surface. Muse represents perhaps the most sophisticated form of the Blind Constructor approach, the emotional and intellectual lineage of ideologists such as Marxists. Their approach embraces complexity, yet not in an attempt to master it through understanding. Instead, Muse seeks to subdue complexity and direct it to their vision through technical virtuosity and grand narrative.

In stark contrast, bands like Pink Floyd, Radiohead, Arcade Fire, and Typhoon craft music that feels alive and evolving. Every album is an experience, one that reinvents itself through a new existential question, typically leading to at least a certain level of despair. The last thing any of these bands could be accused of is delivering purely mechanical, perfectly structured, formulaic music. Instead, their music, and through the music their philosophical thoughts, organically unfold, revealing painful truths about life itself—*much like life, itself*. Their music mirrors the unpredictability of human thought and emotion, much as Dostoevsky's novels and Rachmaninoff's compositions do likewise.

Arcade Fire exemplifies this Pragmatic Architect approach through their sprawling, emotionally raw compositions that evolve throughout the album experience. Albums like "Age of Anxiety," "Reflektor," and "The Suburbs" capture life's messy contradictions. Songs will progress through grief, joy, heartache, contentment, abandonment, companionship, disillusionment, and hope throughout the same journey, often the same song.

If resolution is found, and it usually isn't, one must journey through songs, throughout the album, waiting for the glimpses and moments that offer it. Nothing about what Arcade Fire does is polished into digestible packages. Their music is not designed for the radio, yet their cultural impact demands their songs be played anyway. Still, the concessions made in playing singular

tracks hollow the experience and impact their music was created to evoke. It is hard to describe Arcade Fire's style; their genre changes with each album, yet each album is unmistakably theirs. Throughout their works, one consistency is that their orchestral arrangements swell and recede organically, mirroring the unpredictable nature of human experience itself. Additionally, Arcade Fire embraces moments of beautiful chaos, letting instruments and voices occasionally overwhelm each other in a way that feels authentically human. This is amplified by random choices of unique instrumental additions, idiosyncratic singing styles, and the occasional bilingual transition where Regine Chassagne sings in French as Win Butler sings in English.

Typhoon similarly embodies musical authenticity through their intricate, evolving soundscapes that resist easy categorization, *or any categorization that sufficiently does their best work justice*. Led by Kyle Morton, the band creates compositions that feel like living organisms—growing, changing, and sometimes breaking apart. Their albums, particularly *White Lighter* and *Offerings*, tackle existential themes of mortality, memory, and human frailty with unflinching honesty. In fact, Morton himself perhaps gives the best description of his band, categorizing them as an “existential orchestra.”

Typhoon tackles deep subjects, with big, complex sounds that reject traditional labels and genres. The band includes atypical instruments, utilized in unexpected ways, and at their most sprawling size, such as during my favorite album of theirs—and perhaps generally speaking—*White Lighter*, employing 11 band members across strings, horns, and vocals. When many listen to *White Lighter*, they experience only darkness and hopelessness, while others, feeling these emotions still, experience something much more profound (Boilen, 2013). I find myself in the latter camp because, despite the hopelessness of their music, it paradoxically fills me with hope. Their darkness inspires me, motivates me, and guides me towards optimism. I must clarify, this is not a blind optimism about the inherent goodness of our existence, but rather one that manifests from art, which acknowledges a reality close to the one I see.

Radiohead represents yet another facet of modern musical authenticity. In fact, for those considering only the *sounds* and *arbitrary genres* assigned to them, what I say next will sound absurd. Radiohead was the prototype that paved the way for Arcade Fire, with the bands exuding the same ethos, derived—I am almost certain—from the same telos. Just as I described with Arcade Fire, Radiohead reinvents itself with new, often groundbreaking—even startling—stylistic changes with each album. Thom Yorke sings in ways that can be unsettling in their beauty, seeped in a sorrow the listener cannot shake.

I recall reading that after first recording “Fake Plastic Trees,” Yorke remarked that he collapsed, overcome with emotions, sobbing his eyes out. This is something I relate to intimately, with the specific words, or in Yorke’s case, verses, of my writing—or likely his song—having little to do with this visceral emotional response. The tears flow due to the realizations one comes to about themselves and reality. They continue to come, even once the impact from the unexpected dissolves, due to the memory of the transformation, and the appreciation of the catalyzation that occurred in oneself following the catharsis.

One of the most infuriating comments for Radiohead fans is the assertion that Coldplay is similar in style. I have heard it countless times, and know friends who have likewise been offended, and shocked, by the comparison. When you connect with a band like Radiohead, you are hearing something beyond the music. As such, what others may perceive as a similar sound, for the keen listener, the fan, is a similarity that is something less than irrelevant. A perfect parallel was something I commented on in *The Stone Wall*. Aleksandr Dugin praises Fyodor Dostoevsky, with many believing they are philosophical brethren. As I said in *The Stone Wall*, Dugin is *nothing* like Dostoevsky. Dugin finds intellectual lineage, albeit not ideological, with Tolstoy.

In this manner, rather than similar contemporaries to be compared, Radiohead and Coldplay exist as philosophical opposites to be contrasted. Because, like the other Pragmatic Architects, Radiohead’s songs and albums resist resolution, almost as a law. Instead, they embrace alienation, existential dread, and anxiety. This is an avoidance, and directions Coldplay would never dream of, one that they explicitly avoid.⁹ In short, Radiohead calmly guides us to the abyss, where they remain, content and at peace, at least as far as they are able. Coldplay, on the other hand, works tirelessly to create a narrative in which the abyss is an illusion that doesn’t exist, or if it does, it’s one in which a barely perceptible amount of effort can somehow conquer it.

Finally, the origin of this intellectual lineage, at least in terms of thematic, existentially inspired rock bands, is Pink Floyd. I always *liked* Pink Floyd, appreciating their music and even routinely ranking them in my top 10 bands, but the first time I truly *loved* Pink Floyd, when their music chilled me to the core of my being, was in my 20s, comatose on the couch on a Sunday, hungover from the night before, and staring at the ceiling in existential dread. My roommate had a powerful stereo system that he had just scored for a bargain on Craigslist, and I was

physically incapable of getting up to change the CD he had last played. That CD was *Shine On You Crazy Diamond*.

I stayed on that couch for hours listening to this album on repeat. As I gained the capacity to leave, I lost the will, my mind captivated by what I was hearing for the 100th, but somehow the first, time. On this day *Wish You Were Here* transitioned from what I considered to be a decent, but not great album, to arguably my favorite album at many times of my life, and usually my favorite from Pink Floyd. Because it took me being transformed, impaired, and incapacitated, to truly see, and dare I say understand the album, my curiosity piqued on whether the album had been panned upon release. I suspected it had been, strongly. I was not disappointed.

Nick Kent wrote perhaps the most famous scathing review of the album for NME, asserting that the album was *"bereft of any real originality or inspired conceptualized cognizance," "some of the most labored bouts of aural padding imaginable,"* and asserting that Pink Floyd *"seem so incredibly tired and seemingly bereft of true creative ideas one wonders if they really care about their music anymore."* That review had me chuckling, but it was the words of Ben Edmonds of *Rolling Stone* magazine that had me in hysterics. His review was so preposterous that I had to call my roommate over to read it with me. Edmonds put his pen to paper and decided upon the accusation that Pink Floyd's "lackadaisical demeanor" leaves the subject of Barrett's collapse into mental illness *"unrealised; they give such a matter-of-fact reading of the goddamn thing that they might as well be singing about Roger Waters's brother-in-law getting a parking ticket."* (x)

I can't remember which of us said it, but I remember the finality of our joke, after which we laughed, and we laughed, and we laughed, until suddenly I had forgotten my existential dread, and hangover, for that matter. The joke in question, a quip rather than a comical debate, was what a Pink Floyd band member, or the entire band, must have done in order to incite such undeserved rage from Edmonds. We progressed through many absurd scenarios until deciding that Edmonds must have been forcefully cucked by his wife, sobbing as the entire band was welcomed into her embrace.¹⁰ Only a trauma this deep could possibly justify the words he had written. Today, I defer to Occam's Razor, as well as Hanlon's Razor, letting them guide my

¹⁰ When speaking about the wife of Ben Edmonds, all doubt must be removed: I am not referring to a real human being. If there is a real Mrs. Edmonds, of which there could be, but regardless I am not aware, this crude abstract hypothetical dreamed up by two 20-something-year-olds did not mean to include her. It was an amusing thought experiment in a progressively escalating discussion about the scenario in which a man would be justified in such ridiculous vitriol. Of course, we were projecting a reality onto a typical, honest, and well-intentioned person, and not a vile, hateful little creature needing to attack others to soothe their poisoned soul.

judgment on the matter. It seems more likely that Edmonds was simply an idiot, an archetypical critic devoid of any originality of thought, talent, ability to comprehend complexity, complemented by an unfortunate destructive negativity yielding only unpleasantness. A shallow, sad little man who needs to tear down those more successful to mask the pain of his own inadequacy. I digress.

Much like the bands I have written about previously, Pink Floyd explores themes of existential dread, war, mental illness, and social alienation with a truthful approach that embraces messy emotions and unpredictability. Their music unfolds organically, often with extended instrumental explorations and thematic narratives that avoid formulaic design. Like Arcade Fire, and to an extent Radiohead, their songs do not fit within radio requirements, but because of their impact they are played, regardless. In isolation, something is lost. Pink Floyd's albums deserve the album experience; they demand it.

What remains remarkable to me, what gives me hope, is the popularity of some of these bands. Through this artistic medium, Pragmatic Architects manage to break through. To me, that signals that there may be more architect within us than we realize, for the appreciation of this emotional journey requires one to exist sufficiently towards the center of the spectrum to allow this side of themselves to emerge. So, through Pink Floyd, we find a lineage of great bands, bands that pound a message of reality through the cracks in the fantastical walls built by the Blind Constructors, remaining in the public's attention largely undetected, massively accepted, wearing only a thin veil of musical artistry to mask their uncomfortable truths.

The distinction becomes clear: The Eagles and Coldplay are emotional tamers, avoiding confrontation with life's chaos, while bands like Radiohead and Pink Floyd force listeners to face uncomfortable realities.

The Paradox of Artistic Appeal

From this observation on the polarization of philosophical artistic approaches, a fascinating paradox emerges when we further examine the relationship between artistic approach and commercial intent. On one hand, bands like Coldplay and The Eagles, meticulously engineered for broad appeal, employ techniques that reflect an acute awareness of audience expectations

and market forces. Their music is designed to be immediately accessible and comforting, presenting a structured, controlled version of reality through polished production. The very fact that these bands and artists are able to reliably and repeatedly curate precise formulaic works suggests that it is likely they deeply understand certain emotional drivers present within the majority of people. So, in a way they are confronting reality, *albeit a different angle and perception of our reality*, just as competently as the Pragmatic Architects.

On the other hand, many of the most artistically resonant works come from groups such as Pink Floyd, Radiohead, Arcade Fire, and Typhoon, whose music is driven by a deep internal commitment to authenticity and emotional truth. These artists reject mainstream formulas in favor of capturing the raw, unfiltered complexities of human experience. They stare at the stone wall and resign to thrash themselves into it, demanding their right to live in misery, aware of the wall, yet uncompromising when it comes to the limitations it presents. In this manner, these Pragmatic Architects present a psychological delusion and vulnerability akin to Dostoevsky's underground man, arguably matching, or surpassing the Blind Constructors in their rejection of reality.

Regarding some of the observations I have relayed, I should make it explicitly clear that I realize I am far from the first to note them—for instance, in the Netflix show *Loudermilk*, my exact thoughts were echoed by the lead character, and an artist he had reconnected with. In short, for those who have not watched this somewhat obscure show, *Loudermilk* is a washed-up music critic in recovery. He gets pushed to listen to an artist he believed he had never heard of, just to be shown his unfair, vitriolic negative review, likely written in a drunken or drugged-up stupor of negativity and self-hate, which had derailed her career years before. Confronted with his past self, *Loudermilk* gave the music another listen, realizing he deeply appreciated it.

This cathartic experience drove him to try to make amends with the artist, who was anything but receptive. After finally breaking through and establishing a relationship with her, and determined to guide her career back on track, the pair spent an evening talking about music. *Loudermilk* reflected that truly great music demands more than a single, cursory listen. He presents the argument regarding the injustice it would serve to judge Pink Floyd or Radiohead off of a single listen, to which the artist responds, “or Arcade Fire.” This story arc, culminating in this exchange, embodies precisely what appreciating complex art teaches us about ourselves: our initial discomfort, confusion, or quick dismissal often reflects the limitations in our own understanding, patience, and openness. Rachmaninoff's Piano Concerto No. 3, as an example, received mixed

to negative reviews upon release, as I previously relayed. Critics thought he was making mistakes in his technical playing, not understanding that it was purposeful, and that technical demonstration was not the point of the art he was revealing. It wasn't until a decade later that critics started to appreciate the piece and what it meant.

Conversely, those of us gravitating towards the Pragmatic Architect side must confront the weaknesses in ourselves, lest we devolve into wretched beings, consumed by our own toxicity, living embodiments of Dostoevsky's underground man. We must work to shed our pretension, to concede that others have the right to enjoy the art forms that bring them peace and joy. We must stop being emotionally and artistically presumptuous, falsely equating our existential struggle with an undeniable superiority of intellect. Just as the Blind Constructors must understand the reality Pragmatic Architects see in order to progress towards truth and understanding, so must the Pragmatic Architects endeavor to truly understand, deeply and intimately, the emotional drivers and the worldview that arises from the Blind Constructors, and in which they operate. It is the only path towards enlightenment.

What Our Artistic Preferences Reveal About Us

Since emotion predates cognition, making all cognition the result of an initial, or multiple, emotional responses, it follows that how we respond to mediums that purposefully draw emotion out of us may give an indication of how the other aspects of our worldview are shaped. Very few activities or experiences in this life are able to draw our emotions out as strongly as the various arts, whether they be written, musical, or aesthetic. Amongst reliable activators, none are as universal and general as these art forms, requiring no personal connection to the artist in question. Since cognition follows emotion, and art initiates emotional activation, it follows that by observing *which* emotions particular art forms induce in a particular person, we may be able to ascertain certain aspects of their worldview. Certainly, I would hypothesize that it would be highly likely that strong correlations could be found between art forms enjoyed, and positions on subjects purported to be logically based—such as politics, ethics, morality, and ideal governance, amongst other areas.

Of course, at the moment, this is nothing but a conjecture-driven hypothesis. That said, I implore researchers in relevant fields to design studies that may elucidate this—or could very well serve to create evidence arguing against it. The purpose of science and philosophy is to understand

the world around us. Even though this hypothesis of mine is conjecture-based, I would be remiss not to put it forward. If it proves true, even in weak or moderate correlation, the amount of untapped data available for the few social scientists left who are driven by the pursuit of knowledge and truth is vast beyond anything previously dreamed of. This is because a weak to moderate correlation regarding a single preference in an artistic style or piece may be interesting, but the totality of our appreciations, and hatreds, in regards to numerous artforms could be predictive of almost all of our beliefs, behavioral tendencies, and critically by tracking how these preferences change over time, of the trajectory our biases and ideologies are traveling, and the speed at which they are advancing.

As I alluded to in the previous section, art is subjective, with neither pole at each end of the spectrum being superior to the other. In fact, the vast majority of art, maybe all, exists somewhere in between the extremes, with perhaps no perfect example of a work devoid completely of the tendencies from the opposing pole. Albeit, even though all art exists within the spectrum, this doesn't mean that art is evenly spread through the spectrum. Just as behavioral tendencies in biological sexes tend to cluster near each end—except for sexual preference, which is much closer to “the middle” for females than males—most art gravitates towards one extreme, and of that majority, the majority gravitates towards the Blind Constructor framework.

As I argued throughout *The Stone Wall*, we cannot understand others until we first understand ourselves. Absolutely, we must explore this thought line to determine if it has merit on a macro, population-wide level, but for the time being, for those endeavoring to improve themselves and become who they envision they already are, the artistic preferences you gravitate to hold a key to part of your *self*, *which* is unlikely you have ever fully accessed. As an exercise for the reader, think deeply about your musical, literary, and aesthetic preferences. Do they gravitate to order, with predictable emotional arcs ending in resolution? These are typical Blind Constructor qualities. Or do they evoke chaos, despair, disillusionment, and other undesirable feelings? Namely, the feelings that the Pragmatic Architects design their work to bring forth from their audience. Then, consider music that does the opposite, namely, for those gravitating to the Blind Constructors, how does the art of the Pragmatic Architects make you feel? Is it universal, or selective? The same question must be asked by those preferring Pragmatic Architects in regards to the works of the Blind Constructors.

By assessing the totality of our preferences, one can begin to ascertain where on the reality assessing spectrum they stand, which further allows contemplation and analysis of inherent biases and preferences in supposedly logic-driven decisions and allegiances. Once these

revelations are made, it becomes easier to deeply consider the emotionally driven worldview of others, as well. Analyzing reality through the lens of others helps us identify similarities in desired outcomes, as well as in observed challenges. From these commonalities, we will become more adept at working together to find agreeable solutions, solutions that satisfy the emotional reactions of the majority throughout the entire spectrum.

The purpose of this divergence back to the *self* is not to derail the discussion of education, but to shine light upon an aspect in which our schooling is lacking. Education today, focusing on memorization and regurgitation, lacks a coherent mechanism to aid our youth in understanding *how* they know what they know. In order to alter ourselves, to expand our ability and create comprehensive and intelligible systems that may improve our societal function in the future, we must begin with the *how* and the *why*. Without the *how* and *why*, we will continue to march forward, blinders on our eyes and without a driver holding the reins. Eventually, inevitably, unable to see the entirety of what surrounds us, catastrophe will occur.

So, we must free ourselves, and subsequently our future generations, from the blinders stymieing our ability to expand into an advanced state of meta-awareness. Without action, we condemn ourselves and our future to be trapped in the prison of our unconscious preferences and biases, incapable of understanding how said biases shape our individual reality into observed truths, which contrast and conflict with the individual reality of our fellow inhabitants. We share space and time with each other, and some facts are observable truths we can agree on, but the majority of our existence is shrouded in the biases created by our emotionally derived orientations. Understanding ourselves is the key that unshackles our minds, and with that key, we can work to help others remove their shackles, too.

If you don't, Big Tech companies will continue to do precisely this to predict all of our behavior. The difference being they do not publish their data and findings, nor do they utilize said learning to benefit users or society in general. They have mastered this meta-analysis of what constitutes the *self* for their own selfish gain. They use this deep knowledge to control us, to lord as masters over us. It is time we learn these truths about ourselves and our reality so that we can use this knowledge as a key to free ourselves from the weight and weakness of our unawareness and to simultaneously break the shackles of these would-be technocratic overlords.

Implications for Educational Reform

“This goes to show that there are many variables in each man's impressions of the invisible world. The points of contact vary, the stereotyped expectations vary, the interest enlisted varies most subtly of all. The living impressions of a large number of people are to an immeasurable degree personal in each of them, and unmanageably complex in the mass. How, then, is any practical relationship established between what is in people's heads and what is out there beyond their ken in the environment? How in the language of democratic theory, do great numbers of people feeling each so privately about so abstract a picture, develop any common will? How does a simple and constant idea emerge from this complex of variables? How are those things known as the Will of the People, or the National Purpose, or Public Opinion crystallized out of such fleeting and casual imagery?” - Walter Lippmann (p. 108)

We must accept that the quest to understand ourselves and others through the emotional framing each of us views the world through is a task of utmost importance. Our education cannot adequately accomplish its purported purpose without this acknowledgement, and I fear that the fate of our respected democracies is teetering on the edge of a cliff, susceptible to being toppled by a strong gust of misunderstanding. As I wrote about in *The Stone Wall*, we must first understand ourselves in order to begin the process of understanding others, after which we can set ourselves to the task of evaluating small group dynamics. Eventually, the scale of our analysis can grow larger and larger, with the end goal of coherent estimations of the actions of society as a whole.

As adults, we are required to accept reality for what it is—both the reality observed by Pragmatic Architects, and that felt by the Blind Constructors,¹¹ as well as all that exists between the two opposites. They are two halves of our existence, and the complete focus on either, to the denial of the other, leads us to catastrophe. As we understand this as adults, we must endeavor to train it into our youth, implementing corrections and adjustments as soon as new knowledge or data emerges. In the next chapter, I detail my proposals on primary educational reform, predicated upon the principles and concepts found within this chapter, leading to the frameworks and intended solutions for advanced education and the workplace, which I will detail in the chapters following the next.

Importantly, in addition to understanding that individuals see reality in wildly different ways at each end of the spectrum, we must accept the uncomfortable truth that they also assess these variables, highly individualized visions of our world, with massive differences in mental capacity. It is the totality of what we see, how we interpret it, and our capacity to make sense of it that allows us to channel our emotions and direct our learning towards decisions and paths. These decisions, and the paths they take us down, matter greatly, for they determine whether we succeed or fail, and if our involvement in society benefits it, or harms it. Critically, forcing all individuals down the same path will lead the majority to fail on both of these measured outcomes—as will expecting that all of those within a specific path will be able to achieve, or deserve, equity.

I understand the objection to teaching children the inherent truths of hierarchy. We fear that they may not understand, and that through their misunderstandings, they may accelerate down a pathway which exacerbates the worst hierarchical qualities, rationalizing cruelty and seeking domination over others. This is a legitimate fear, but the fear is born in error, namely by the assumption that our incoherent structures of today must continue to prevail in future scenarios. The greatest irony is that in our quest for equity, we have exacerbated the chasm between competency levels. To compensate for this, we have altered structures so that competence has ceased to be a predictor of success within our institutional frameworks, whether it be education, government, or many multinational corporations. The loss of competence is leading to the unraveling of our society, compounded by the deterioration of roles we desperately need, but have arbitrarily determined are of low status—a deep irony in this nonsensical endeavor for DEI.

I have opined that while I can invent patentable technologies that are seemingly of interest to society, from consumers all the way up to top professors and Medical Practitioners, found and scale extremely successful businesses with little to no seed capital, self-funded to avoid corrupted purpose from venture capitalists and investors, published academic papers, wrote books on philosophy, politics, health, and more, that if I had been directed down another path I would be a complete failure. If society pushed me into being an electrician, for instance, the traits that allow me to think deeply would be a considerable danger. I would likely be dead from electrocuting myself, and many of the houses or buildings I would work on would ultimately be consumed by a fiery hell. Thankfully, this isn't my reality.

Likewise, if I had been pushed into being a carpenter, it is almost certain I would be of quite low quality, exacerbated by the fingers I presume I would be missing. Of note: the only class I ever

had to spend extra time and effort on, staying late after school every day to avoid failing, was the “shop” class I took in the 8th grade. I had precisely zero talent for it, and was making so many mistakes and errors necessitating me starting over again each time that I am certain I added more grey hairs and wrinkles to the kind teacher who allowed me to keep trying.

Finally, if I were tasked with caring for young children, it is almost certain it would end in disaster. I do not say that lightly. Watching my children, for instance, for two hours, requiring 100% of my attention and focus, drains me to the point of needing a nap. It is simply not what my mind is good at. I begin losing concentration, sometimes stumbling to be able to speak. My mind is simply not equipped to excel at a task like this. Thankfully, there are people in my life who do excel at this, such as my wife, my mother when she visits, and the help we are fortunate enough to be able to afford.

This brings me to the point of my argument. Just as I am unfit for many positions and roles we absolutely need for societal function, the vast majority of individuals we are pushing down specific pathways, such as to work in office jobs, the sciences, business, government, and many other positions historically requiring a structured—and usually completely worthless—university education are completely unfit and incapable of competently doing these roles. Yet, they may have made fantastic electricians, carpenters, house makers, and parents, or many of the other critical job duties we are desperately in need of.

Forcing everyone down the same pathway creates bitterness and resentment, leading to complex hierarchical power dynamics. It leads to contempt on one end and *ressentiment* on the other. Moreover, it solidifies hierarchical-driven dismissiveness and discrimination against individuals who opted to take traditional pathways that suit their nature, such as men working in the trades and women raising a family. This ironic paradox further emerges when the exact same ideologues posit that these positions are *lowly*, labeling critics who call for increasing societal output in these roles domestically as discriminatory, just to contend that we must import the third world into our nations in order to fill these gaps, namely, to ensure we have laborers, frontline workers, and a growing population.

These ideologues are implying that these societal duties are *beneath* even the lowest IQ quartile born into our Western nations, while simultaneously declaring that the migrants filling these roles *ought to fill these roles*. The logic follows that they believe in their hearts, and unspoken narratives, that the migrants are beneath the lowest born into our society. Yet, those

who question the need to bring in these masses from poorer nations are declared as racists. I want to be very clear, this is *not* an argument against immigration. It is an argument against forcing pathways into societal roles based on where an individual was born, a policy that is inherently racist, or at least culturally discriminative, authoritarian, idiotic, and, at the very least, subconsciously hateful.

My primary educational plan will seek to strip these assumptions, aiming to learn about individuals, allowing them to be gently guided down the path that serves their individual nature. Hierarchy will always exist, and the precise power dynamics of each subcategory within the hierarchy will always explicitly depend on “supply and demand,” which is precisely why we need to remove the forced tunneling of all down a path that only serves the few. By doing this, actual power imbalances will be attenuated, while societal function will dramatically improve. We must only shed our assumed biases, and learned prejudices—the ones which were ironically amplified by those attempting to remove these very bigotries in the first place.

Conclusion: The Path Forward

The solution I will put forth in the next chapter seeks to restore harmony. It seeks to mitigate the worst of human nature, such as power seeking and division, paradoxically, through accepting them as reality. By attempting to subdue what is innate within us, we ensure that reality presents itself as a caricature of our worst qualities. This is what the Blind Constructors get wrong, but the solution from many Pragmatic Architects—namely, what amounts to soft nihilism—is equally uninspiring.

Instead, we must channel the best traits of each extreme, and empower all of those within the spectrum to pursue their strengths to their own ends, but also to the benefit of civilization. The Blind Constructors and Pragmatic Architects must tame each other, so that the former cannot push for a solution that they believe is perfection, but in reality is catastrophic, whereas the latter cannot ridicule the former for aspiring to try, relegating themselves to defeat in the face of the stone wall.

This embrace of the two poles, accepting each for the duty and service they provide to thought, truth, and insight into our reality, leads to a beneficial creative tension. It pushes us to recognize

human limitations, while simultaneously aspiring towards human flourishing. It acknowledges our rationality without abandoning the pursuit of reason, and accepts our innate tribal, selfish, and hierarchical tendencies, without neglecting our moral concerns—in fact, as I previously argued, by acknowledging innate realities, while rejecting said realities as deterministic prisons, we are freed to develop moral frameworks that could greatly surpass our flawed historical attempts. Like the aforementioned engineer who neither ignores gravity nor considers it an insurmountable obstacle, this approach works within constraints to create something beautiful and functional.

In short, we need to wipe the board clean and reframe our entire perception of education through a scientific lens. Currently, we are operating ideologically. Namely, we assume the truth of our paradigm, attempting to tweak strategies within the assumed truth. The problem is, this truth is demonstrably false. By restarting from scratch, we must first acknowledge how and why we think and act the ways we do, and how our environment leads us to these thoughts—a potential answer being what I have hypothesized above, which aligns largely with the empirical evidence in various fields. By building a foundation from what is empirical, and stripping the dogmatic ideologies that have proven disastrous, we can begin to imperfectly, but intentionally, design an evidence-based educational model that maximizes human potential. The next chapter serves as a starting point, not the finish line. It amounts to my suggested solutions, and I implore all of those willing and able to think deeply about the subject to engage with the concepts, and work with me and others to improve the logic, design, and root out any potential failures.

The responsibility for a future built upon shared truths, harmony, and prosperity rests on each of our shoulders. It is time we engage with each other, while we are still able.

Educational reform must begin with this honest acknowledgment of human nature—not just in abstract theory but in practical design. It means creating learning environments that engage emotion alongside intellect, acknowledge status dynamics rather than pretending they don't exist, account for tribal psychology while expanding its boundaries, and recognize cognitive biases while developing metacognitive awareness to mitigate them.

The greatest achievements in human history—whether artistic, scientific, or political—have come from those who neither denied human nature nor resigned themselves to its limitations, but worked within reality to transform it. From Dostoevsky's ability to find redemption within

human darkness to constitutional democracies that channel self-interest towards public good, these achievements embody the Pragmatic Architect approach.

Our educational system must cultivate this same approach—producing graduates who understand human nature in all its complexity and can design systems aligned with rather than opposed to human reality. Only then can we address the challenges facing our civilization, from climate change to technological governance to social cohesion.

The choice is clear: either we continue producing graduates blinded by theoretical constructs disconnected from human reality, or we create an educational system that embraces the complexity of human nature and prepares students to navigate it effectively. If we fail to align education with human nature, we will continue producing leaders who ignore reality, thinkers trapped in theory, and citizens unequipped for the world they inhabit. The result will not just be failure—it will be collapse, as systems built on false assumptions inevitably self-destruct.

DRAFT!!!!

This is a rough draft on “a tale of two bands” addition:

RH vs CP

Coldplay “I wanna... bigger... stronger... drive a faster car... I will settle for nothing less... I wanna be strong”

First EP a contrast of sad music, sad singing, few musical resolutions, but hopeful and aspirational lyrics

Ends with “such a rush... such a rush... everybody’s out there trying to get money”

Parachutes starts hopeful and uplifting

Some sad songs that find no resolution, but they're very personal, as in conveying individualistic regret in decisions and events, not so much bemoaning reality, humanity, society (trouble, we never change)

Ends hopeful in "everything's not lost"

A rush of blood to the head is where Coldplay starts finding their footing in the BC camp, but still have traces pulling them to be confused with PAs, although they never were.

The scientist doesn't emotionally resolve, and it doesn't musically uplift, but it remains consistent—there is no disorienting chaos to cause unease. It's just general, individualized remorse that BC type thinkers do not shy from

Clocks represents perhaps the first real attempt at reconciling despair with resolution and hope. Lyrics like "the lights go out and I can't be saved" and "confusion that never stops / closing walls and ticking clocks" and "am I part of the cure / or am I part of the disease" are contrasted against uplifting music. Yet, within the lyrics it still focuses on individualized regret, "cursed missed opportunities" and "gonna come back and take you home." Critically, the band in Clocks hasn't yet hit their stride in formulaic construction.

-as Coldplay gained more success they became more positive, uplifting, confident, finding their stride as BCs

Fix You, to me, is their statement that the band had mastered their formula. Despite perfectly fitting into the blind constructor camp, I find the song moving. Perhaps it appeals to my protector instincts. The lyrics are emotionally powerful, and the music is likewise powerful. It starts slow, setting a tone of emotional gravity, slowly picking up, before exploding into hope and optimism at the end of the song—despite the message of the lyrics never changing. Fix You became a live anthem for the band, a song fans routinely sing along to

The smashing success of Fix You led to Coldplay fully embracing the blind constructor archetype, at which point their popularity continued to rise. Chris Martin got his fast car, he became stronger, richer, and ascended to his goals, along with the rest of the band.

Radiohead: creep...

Radiohead, in contrast, began with an album that fit nicely into the popular and emerging Grunge category in Pablo Honey. Musically it was much less pessimistic and depressing than early Coldplay, with the exception of their haunting and emotionally transcendent "Creep," a song Thom Yorke once said he would never play again, even if the queen of England offered him a million pounds to play for her. Of course, Thom did eventually release a cover of his own song in 202x. The pessimism and sadness in Creep is more existential, the lyrics Thom writes and sings more about the reality of his existence, his soul, his place in society. He views himself as a creep, he doesn't belong, whereas Chris Martin's lyrics, while singing of missed opportunities and regret, are aspirational in the sense he believes he deserves more

Despite success with Creep and Pablo Honey, Radiohead reinvented themselves with The Bends. Songs that, despite sad lyrics, uplift while delivering emotional weight include High and Dry, which could be compared to Coldplay's The Scientist and Clocks in terms of lyrical weight contrasted with somewhat upbeat and consistent music.

Also on The Bends were tracks that spoke more true to their pragmatic architect tendencies, yet still finding the need to insert hope and feeble attempts at resolution at the end. fake plastic trees alludes to hope, with the song briefly building energy and momentum for the lyrics "but I can't help the feeling / I could blow through the ceiling / if I just turn and run," before promptly killing the energy and transitioning to the lyrics "and it wears me out (repeated x4) / if I could be who you wanted (x2) / all the time (x2) before ending trailing off into despair.

Street spirit / fade out tells a story of crushing dread about society and the band's place in it. "Rows of houses all bearing down on me... all these things we'll one day swallow whole / this machine will, will not communicate / these thoughts and the strain I am under / be a world child form a circle / before we all go under. Yorke goes on to sing "I can feel death, can see its beedy eyes / all these things into position, before repeating "all these things will one day swallow whole," and the chorus "and fade out again (x2). The music, intense, powerful, and haunting throughout the cynical lyrics, transitions to deflated, almost hopeless, as Yorke pleads with the listener to "immerse your soul in love" first powerfully, and then a second time in a manner that seems to be speaking to himself, not the listener, as the music trails off.

The Bends was a critical and commercial success, but unlike Coldplay, Radiohead did not move towards refining and perfecting their music. In fact, it seems the commercial success of The Bends led them to greater experimentation, and a deeper existential angst, in OK computer. Paranoid Android is almost indescribable, a fever dream of emotions and musical cadence and emotional intensity changes. Karma Police serves as a biting criticism against the emerging far left and their social demands, namely their demand for unlimited empathy, to the point of totalitarian control. The lyrics “karma police, I’ve given all I can / it’s not enough, I’ve given all I can” before singing “for a minute there / I lost myself (repeat x3).

Exit Music (for a film) offers no resolution of any kind. The music is haunting, and the lyrics only intensify the despair. “Wake from your sleep / the drying of your tears / today we escape... breathe, keep breathing / I can’t do this alone... and you can laugh / a spineless laugh / we hope your rules and wisdom choke you / and now we are one / in everlasting peace / we hope that you choke, that you choke (x3) as the music trails off. Let Down continues this energy from another angle, slightly more uplifting music contrasted against lyrics such as “the emptiest of feelings, disappointed people / clinging onto bottles / when it comes it’s so, so disappointing / let down and hanging around / crushed like a bug in the ground.” Yorke goes on to sing through brief emotional hope, and immediate collapse into despair, singing “legs are going, don’t get sentimental / it always ends up in drivel / one day I am going to grow wings / a chemical reaction / hysterical and useless, hysterical and / let down and hanging around / crushed like a bug in the ground.” The musical intensity of Let Down is contrasted against lyrics of sadness, on the surface similarly to Coldplays fix you, but in reality the antithesis. Fix You exudes hope while Let Down delivers despair.

Again, OK Computer was met with critical and commercial success. Yet still, the band refused to be defined. They released two experimental albums in quick succession, Kid A and Amnesiac, that divided fans and critics. The tone changed in their next album, Hail to the Thief, a play on the American presidential anthem “hail to the chief,” where anger seemed to have replaced despair. 2 + 2= 5 opens the album, where Yorke sings lyrics, condescendingly, that concisely portray blind constructor mentality, while seemingly nodding at Dostoevsky’s underground man and the stone wall “are you such a dreamer / to put the world to rights / I’ll stay home forever / where two and two always makes five.” He continues “it’s the devils way now / there is no way out / you can scream and you can shout / it’s too late now / because... you have not been /

paying attention (x5) repeated four times angrily, and ending the song in a scattered conversation with himself expressing doubt between the extremes. There, There returns to depression and philosophical pessimism, with lyrics such as “just cause you feel it / doesn’t mean it’s there, and “we are accidents / waiting, waiting to happen.” While “go to sleep” delivers a message of giving up. Hail to the Thief marked a return to critical acclaim, perhaps not despite, but because of the anger, despair, and cynicism they unleashed.

Then, something happened. Radiohead recorded their next album without a record label. They released the 2007 album, In Rainbows, at the same time for everyone worldwide, fans and critics, for any price they wanted—including \$0. Media, fellow artists, and fans alike responded almost universally and overwhelmingly positively, praising the moment of unity. Time called it “easily the most important release in the recent history of the music business,” although some artists did criticize the move—Trent Reznor of Nine Inch Nails felt the band hasn’t gone far enough, while others feared that Radiohead’s effort would hurt smaller artists that didn’t have the financial security to offer the same gift to fans.

What truly sets apart In Rainbows was the album’s message of hope. Reckoner, one of the most hauntingly beautiful songs I’ve ever heard, is a piece that many people I know, who otherwise viscerally hate Radiohead, appreciate, even love. What truly matters is that Reckoner is also widely praised and loved by Radiohead fans who had connected with the earlier, darker music. Lyrics are honest, Yorke singing “you can’t take it with you / dancing for your pleasure, contrasted against “you are not to blame for / bittersweet distracts.” He continues to sing, paraphrasing the lyrics, that the song is dedicated to all, alluding to how we are separate yet together—like ripples on a blank shore. In Rainbows, for me, is the mark where Radiohead transcends from a defeated pragmatic architect, fighting the abyss, defending against the descent into being one with the underground man, to uniting the hope of the blind constructor with the clarity of the pragmatic architect. I’ve thought about this countless times, and every time I let, or direct my mind to this thought, I’m overwhelmed with a mix of emotions that is hard to describe.

Radiohead transcended genres, they transcended music, and importantly, they transcended the archetypal limitations that have destroyed many of us who are afflicted with similar lenses for viewing reality. In the end, they transcended themselves. Coldplay became who they dreamed

of becoming, a reality they carefully constructed. Radiohead battled through the fire, fought off the abyss, and through this struggle of becoming found who they needed to be, in order to be.